Mamarinta B. Lao

Brigadier General Mamarinta B. Lao (February 29, 1916 - 2005) was a decorated Filipino military officer, a Meranao royal noble, and one of the most consequential figures in the history of Muslim Filipinos in national service.

Born into a centuries-old royal lineage from the shores of Lake Lanao, he went on to break one of the most enduring barriers in the Armed Forces of the Philippines: he became the **first career Filipino-Muslim and the first Meranao officer to ever attain the rank of General** in the AFP's regular standing forces.

His story spans World War II guerrilla heroics, decades of peacetime military command, provincial governance during Mindanao's most turbulent years, and a cultural legacy that continues to resonate with the Meranao people and the Bangsamoro region to this day.

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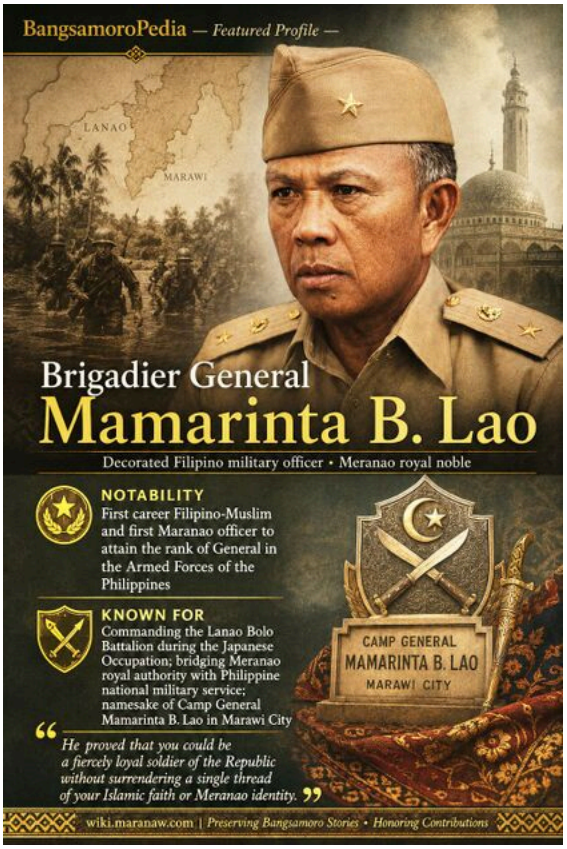
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Background and Royal Lineage

Mamarinta Lao came into the world on a date that comes around only once every four years: **February 29, 1916**, in the ancestral settlement of Macadar, in the municipality of Lumbatan, Lanao del Sur.

He wasn't just a child of that lakeside community; he was born into one of its most distinguished noble families.

Brigadier General Mamarinta B. Lao



Born

February 29, 1916 at Macadar, Lumbatan, Lanao del Sur, Philippines

Died

2005 (aged 89), Macadar, Lumbatan, Lanao del Sur, Philippines

Ethnicity

Meranao

Religion

Islam

Allegiance

Republic of the Philippines

Branch of Service

Armed Forces of the Philippines (AFP); Philippine Constabulary (PC)

Rank

Both of his parents traced their ancestry directly to the *Pat ka Lokes sa Macadar,* which translates roughly as the Four Royal Ancestors of Macadar, the foundational ruling houses of that settlement.

According to local *salsila* (genealogical records), his bloodline ran deep into the Unayan principality, descending from the royal ancestor Akonga and the princess Paramata Andong.

His father, Datu Abdullah, was a direct descendant of a lineage of regional leaders that included Sultan Mardan, Datu Kalipa, and Tomindug.

Growing up surrounded by this heritage, the young Mamarinta was raised with a clear understanding that leadership wasn't optional for him; it was a responsibility that came with his bloodline.

Education

Long before he ever wore a uniform, Lao earned a reputation as a sharp and driven student, which was no small feat in a time when formal education was still finding its footing in rural Mindanao.

He completed his primary schooling in Macadar and Managan, finishing consistently at the top of his classes.

For his secondary education, he attended the Lumbatan Agricultural High School (LAHS), where he graduated as **Valedictorian**.

He then continued his studies at the Lanao Provincial Normal School, completing a two-year collegiate program with high honors.

By the time he was ready to take on greater responsibilities, Lao was that rare combination: a deeply rooted Meranao noble who was also fully conversant in the legal and administrative realities of the American Commonwealth government.

Brigadier General

Commands Held

Lanao Bolo Battalion (1942), Provincial Commander, PC Sulu

Wars and Conflicts

World War II, Philippine Resistance, 1942-1945)

Political Office

Governor of Lanao del Sur (1975-1976)

Royal Title

Noble of the *Pat ka Lokes sa Macadar* (Four Royal Ancestors of Macadar); descendant of the Unayan principality

Resting Place

Macadar, Lumbatan, Lanao del Sur

NOTABILITY

First career Filipino-Muslim and first Maranao officer to attain the rank of General in the Armed Forces of the Philippines

KNOWN FOR

Commanding the Lanao Bolo Battalion during the Japanese Occupation; bridging Meranao royal authority with Philippine national military service; namesake of Camp General Mamarinta B. Lao in Marawi City

PULL QUOTE

"He proved that you could be a fiercely loyal soldier of the Republic without surrendering a single thread of your Islamic faith or Meranao identity."

World War II: The Lanao Bolo Battalion

When Japanese Imperial Forces swept through the Philippines in early 1942, the regular USAFFE units were quickly overwhelmed.

U.S. Brigadier General Guy Fort recognized that the fiercely independent warrior spirit of the Moro people could be organized into a formidable resistance force.

In **January 1942**, Fort formally authorized the creation of the **Lanao Bolo Battalion**, a specialized guerrilla unit built around the fighting traditions and territorial knowledge of the Meranao people.

The young **Lieutenant Mamarinta Lao** was appointed as the battalion's overall commander.

It was a role that demanded far more than battlefield courage.

The challenge was administrative and diplomatic as much as military: Lao had to unify localized combat sectors commanded by proud, fiercely independent Datus who traditionally answered to no outside authority.

Armed with kampilans, bolos, and whatever firearms they could secure, the Lanao Bolo Battalion harassed Japanese supply lines, executed intelligence operations, and held the rugged mountain terrain of Ranao against a determined occupying force.

The Japanese never fully subdued the interior of Lanao del Sur, and Lao's coordination of these resistance networks was a major reason why.

Career: Rising Through the Ranks

After the war, Lao returned to a peacetime military that was still largely unfamiliar with the idea of a Muslim officer climbing the institutional ladder of the regular AFP.

He climbed anyway.

Over a multi-decade career marked by tactical competence, peacekeeping operations across Mindanao, and steady institutional service, Lao worked his way from wartime lieutenant to full general officer.

One of his most significant mid-career postings was as the **Provincial Commander of the Philippine Constabulary (PC) in Sulu**, where he was deployed during the height of the mid-century anti-insurgency campaigns of the 1950s.

National Artist for Literature F. Sionil Jose, who covered the Kamlon Campaign in Sulu as a journalist during that period, explicitly noted serving alongside then-Colonel Mamarinta Lao during those tense years.

When he was finally elevated to **Brigadier General**, it wasn't just a personal milestone; it was a watershed moment for Muslim Filipinos everywhere.

The First Muslim General: Context and Distinction

It's worth pausing to be precise about this claim, because the history can get a bit tangled.

Other legendary Muslim Filipinos, including Salipada K. Pendatun of Cotabato, also held the title of Brigadier General.

But Pendatun's rank was primarily rooted in his wartime guerrilla command and subsequent political-military appointments.

What made Lao's achievement historically distinct was that he earned his generalship by climbing the **regular, peacetime promotion ladder** of the AFP's standing forces, proving that a Filipino-Muslim officer could advance through the standard institutional hierarchy on the strength of merit and service alone.

Historical records, including documentation from UP Diliman ROTC Vanguard logs, confirm that General Lao is recognized as the **first career Filipino-Muslim and first Meranao officer to attain a generalship in the regular AFP officer corps**.

Governance: Governor of Lanao del Sur

After retiring from active military duty, Lao's service to his people wasn't finished.

During the volatile mid-1970s in Mindanao, when political stability in the region was fragile at best, he stepped into civilian governance.

He served as **Governor of Lanao del Sur from 1975 to 1976**, succeeding Princess Tarhata Alonto-Lucman and preceding Mohammad Ali Dimaporo in that office.

His term was a critical stabilizing interlude, drawing on both his military authority and his deep personal credibility among the Meranao people to hold the province steady through a difficult transition.

Legacy: Camp General Mamarinta B. Lao

The most visible tribute to his enduring legacy stands in **Marawi City**.

Through Regional Legislative Assembly (RLA) Bill No. 26, the historic military reservation formerly known as **Campo Ranao**, the strategic nerve center of military operations in Lanao del Sur, was officially renamed **Camp General Mamarinta B. Lao**.

This wasn't a ceremonial gesture.

Campo Ranao had been the tactical heart of military activity in the province since the American colonial era, and giving it General Lao's name tied the identity of that institution permanently to the legacy of indigenous Muslim military leadership.

Every soldier who passes through its gates today does so under a name that stands for something: that being Meranao and being Filipino aren't in conflict.

Cultural Significance

To the Meranao people, General Lao was something the formal record can't fully capture: a bridge.

He lived during a period when the relationship between Manila and the Muslim communities of Mindanao was frequently strained by distrust, distance, and competing interests.

Lao occupied a unique middle ground that few people could claim.

Because of his royal lineage, the Datus and Sultans of Ranao trusted him as one of their own.

Because of his military record, the top brass in Manila took his counsel seriously.

He used that position not just for personal advancement but to defuse local conflicts, push for infrastructure and educational investment in Lanao, and open doors for a younger generation of Muslim Filipinos who wanted to serve their country in uniform.

He lived his entire career as proof that Islamic faith, Meranao identity, and loyal Philippine military service could coexist without contradiction.

Death and Final Rest

General Mamarinta B. Lao passed away in **2005**, at the age of **89**.

In a fitting final chapter, he was returned to his roots.

He was laid to rest with full military honors in his ancestral hometown of **Macadar, Lumbatan**, the same community where he was born nearly nine decades earlier.

He left behind not just a decorated military record but a template: a living demonstration that the sons and daughters of the Lake could serve, lead, and excel at the highest levels of national life without losing themselves in the process.

Recognition and Honors

- **Brigadier General**, Armed Forces of the Philippines (highest military rank, career track)
- **Valedictorian**, Lumbatan Agricultural High School
- **Commander**, Lanao Bolo Battalion (World War II resistance)
- **Provincial Commander**, Philippine Constabulary, Sulu
- **Governor of Lanao del Sur** (1975-1976)
- **Camp Namesake**: Campo Ranao in Marawi City officially renamed Camp General Mamarinta B. Lao (RLA Bill No. 26)

See Also

- Bangsamoro
- Meranao people
- Lanao del Sur
- Marawi City
- Armed Forces of the Philippines
- Philippine Constabulary
- Lanao Bolo Battalion
- World War II in the Philippines
- Salipada K. Pendatun

References

Content was sourced **online using Google AI** (https://tinyurl.com/ykne5dkc)

External Links

- RLA Bill No. 26: Official Renaming of Campo Ranao to Camp General Mamarinta B. Lao (https://lawphil.net/administ/mmaa/7a/pdf/mmaa_301_7a.pdf)
- Lanao del Sur, Wikipedia (https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Lanao_del_Sur)

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